States of Mind presents

*Self*ology

An introduction to the course

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Bea Herbert
Founder

I have experienced time and time again how psychology can change our perception of ourselves, our problems and the world around us.

This course has been designed to offer a starting point for self-exploration and to help people recover their self-esteem by turning inwards and remembering the resources they have within themselves. I believe that we are all experts of our own experience and this course is intended to provide a framework for developing a deeper level of self-awareness, the foundation and catalyst for personal growth.

Our mission with States of Mind is to create therapeutic spaces in homes, schools, between friends and for ourselves, so that support is not restricted to clinical settings but can be found in our everyday lives.



Ella Gregory
Co-designer

Creating this course alongside Bea was an important process for me. I wanted to create something that could give young people a sense of agency over their mental health and a sense of responsibility, something that I had grappled with for years and only truly understood after I had experienced my lowest points.

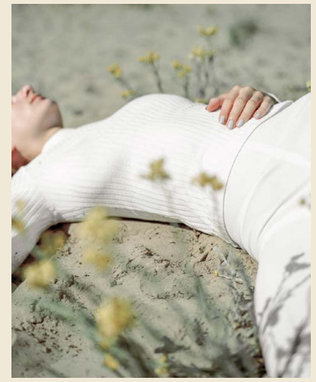
The handbook allows young people to apply the information they have learnt to themselves, a process that is vital for developing self awareness and understanding. What makes this course so special is the humanity that shines through. There is an understanding that this is a course for all of us, made by people who care, and as a result there is a continuous feeling of support and compassion.

Facilitating this course allows that atmosphere to extend beyond the individual and is a beautiful chance to enhance learning in groups.

Learning from others is what made this course possible and is what will make it useful for both young people and the facilitator work for developing a deeper level of self-awareness, the foundation and catalyst for personal growth.

Why we created *Self*ology





The purpose of Selfology is to create spaces where young people have the opportunity to express themselves and explore their inner world outside of clinical settings.

Traditionally, young people are provided with these spaces when they are distressed or are deemed to require professional help. Although Selfology is appropriate for these cases, it is intended to provide a more informal learning environment that cultivates healthy forms of self expression and healthy ways of relating in young people's everyday lives.

Selfology is an alternative methodology that reduces the traditional power imbalances that are often present between young people and professionals. It enables psychologists, teachers and other professionals to guide young people to identify and develop the inner resources they have within themselves.

Instead of focusing on individual problems, Selfology provides a practical and relational method that promotes self knowledge, healthy emotional expression and authentic relating. In this way, young people develop an understanding of mental health that moves beyond pathology and are supported to develop the knowledge and skills they need to feel empowered to understand and express their needs in relationship with others.

Selfology was designed to be more than a mental health curriculum. It was designed to enable the opportunity for young people to experience a space where their voices are heard and acknowledged and where adults can provide a safe relational space to explore and validate young people's experiences without predefined outcomes.

This way of working may seem contradictory to some, who are used to working towards predetermined outcomes as a measure of progress and success. Selfology places the emphasis on the process of 'being with' young people, instead of 'doing to', or delivering sessions with the main aim of covering content.

While facilitators who work within a teaching setting may be familiar with learning objectives and assessment, this work does not require formal assessment or for the facilitator to meet an externally set outcome for the group. Through a shared relational space that draws out learning from personal experience of the content, insights will emerge. Boundaries for the session are established by focusing on a particular subject area and using a particular methodology.

The focus, or overall objective, is to develop curiosity towards young people's experience and draw out their views and experiences to inform the learning process. Success is viewed in terms of the relational outcomes that emerge within the group.

Some of these indications may be:

Do young people feel safe within the space?

Do young people feel that their voices are heard and validated within the space?

Are young people able to demonstrate healthy and respectful behaviour towards others in the group?

Are young people able to develop a sense of insight into their experiences through group activities?

Do young people feel able to communicate when they feel uncomfortable or are struggling with an activity?

Are young people able to explore aspects of their experience they would otherwise not feel safe to?

Exploring this could look like:

1. Checking in with the group at the beginning and end of the session to understand how young people are experiencing the sessions.

2.Inviting the group to provide feedback and suggestions for what is working well and what could work better, to ensure everybody feels comfortable and safe with the group activities and processes.

3. It is also important to recognise that some degree of discomfort is normal, natural and to be expected when discussing topics that feel personal. The aim is to create a space where, over time, the group becomes comfortable with each other and learn how to communicate their needs.



Selfology

Guidance for Facilitators

The Selfology Facilitator Guides have been designed to support you to create spaces where young people can safely explore and discuss their inner world. We have provided guidance, suggestions and session plans for you to use the resources in your setting.

The guidebooks are made up of a selection of discussions, infographics, guided meditations and activities. We provide a recommended timeframe for each session but these resources can be used flexibly depending on the time available.

The purpose is to encourage young people to uncover insights for themselves, to apply their learning to their everyday life and to begin to normalise conversations that explore the more internal aspects of their experience.

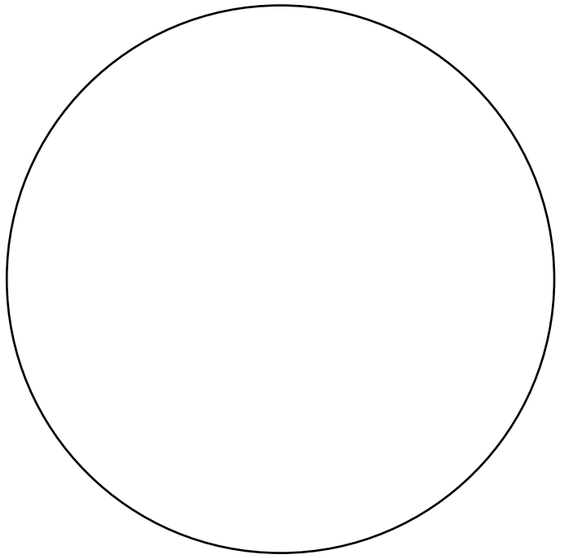
The Facilitator's role is to guide this process of self-discovery, and to provide a safe framework and context to explore their responses to the material.

The meaning and the benefits of this work will be experienced by each person differently.

They are designed to provide a foundation for self-knowledge and a new awareness of how embedding practices in our daily life can support a more healthy perception of ourselves and others. Young people will have ideas of how to use these resources to enable a longer term process of self enquiry and discussion.

The process of learning should be a mutual one, with the facilitator able to model, through experience, the benefits and importance of self reflection and personal enquiry. This contrasts with traditional forms of support, where practitioners take an 'expert' role and are assumed to hold the knowledge. Through this course, young people will be guided and supported to uncover the knowledge they hold within themselves.

We highly recommend that as a facilitator you try some of the practices yourself, to give you a richer understanding of both how to deliver them and how they will be experienced by young people as you facilitate them.



1. No right or wrong
This is not an academic course, the focus is on exploration rather than findings the correct answer. Everybody will bring a different perspective to the material and each person's contribution can lead to a richer understanding of the topic. At the beginning it is helpful to emphasise how everybody is learning from each other and to recognise each contribution is a valuable way for everybody to explore and learn about the topic.

2. Pace and Space
Be sensitive to the pace at which you are delivering the content. Often if you feel you are rushing through the content, it can be a sign that you are disconnecting from the person or group. Focus on the process, not the outcome. Creating space for feedback, checking in and allowing reflections to emerge can produce a more intimate and safe feeling. When you show that you are taking your time, it reflects in the group's sense that there is time to be heard.

3. Reflecting back
A key therapeutic practice to keep in mind is to recognise and reflect back what you have heard from the participants. This may be as simple as summarising what has been shared so that people feel heard, or saying thank you after each contribution. You can also give feedback to the group when you notice there is silence, or a sense of awkwardness. Eg, I notice you feel less able to share about this topic, I'm wondering what's going on for the group now?

4.Balance
There is no need for anybody to share anything they are not comfortable with. If people feel forced to share this can leave them feeling as if they have over-exposed themselves and can cause distress. Often there are some people who are more vocal and will lead the discussions. This can help draw out further conversation that can be used to ask less vocal people about their views. Some activities feel more sensitive than others and people should only share because they feel it is beneficial for their own understanding, rather than feeling forced or pressured to do so.

5. Stay aware of the emotional temperature in the room
This can stir a lot within people so it's important to be mindful of how people are feeling. It's helpful to check in with the group at regular intervals. Even if it feels as though the group is coping well with the material, it shows them you have their feelings in mind.

6. Ending the session
Checking out is a crucial part of the process. It is helpful to include both what they feel they have learned and how they are feeling at the end of the session. Let participants know they can stay behind if they would like to discuss how they are feeling and leave some space for this to happen.

7. Self care
At the end of the session take a few moments to reflect on how this was for you. You may find it helpful to make notes on what came up in the session and any key learning points that you may want to lead on from in the next session. It takes time to feel comfortable delivering the material and finding your own personal style of facilitation. The most important factor is finding an approach that works for you. Take some time to unwind and step back from the material and be mindful of your own emotional responses that came up and how these influence your speed or style of facilitation.

8. Sitting with uncertainty
Throughout the learning process, young people may ask you questions about areas of the content that feel difficult to answer, for example, 'If I have depression, will I have it forever?'. In these situations it is important to be clear and transparent that you are uncertain about the answer and you can use this to inform a discussion within the group by sharing the dilemma or question with the young people to ask for their views, opinions and experiences, or let them know you will explore this for the next session.



Selfology Overview

Each guidebook provides facilitators with guidance for delivering up to 5, 2 hour sessions on key areas related to young people's wellbeing and personal growth.

Body Feelings Mind
Self Awareness
The Johari Window
Mind-Body Approaches
Exploring and Expressing Emotions
Breathing Practice
Mindsets
Identity and Personality
Personal identity
Life events and Personal history
Post Traumatic Growth
Sub Personalities
Family and Relationships
Types of Relationships
Attachment styles and ways of relating
Misunderstandings in Relationships
Mentalising
Supportive relationships
Listening Skills
Anxiety
Internal and External Fears
Anxiety and Control
Anxiety and Emotional Regulation
Anxiety and Coping Mechanisms
The Task Positive Network
Anxiety and Self Compassion

Creating a safe space for self enquiry

Session 1

Discussion 1: Personal Introductions

In pairs, take 2 minutes each to introduce yourself to your partner and discuss what motivated you to be a part of this group. When each person has shared, invite each person to introduce their partner and their motivation for being here.

As each person shares, feedback common themes or patterns that you notice in the reasons why young people wanted to be part of the group. Acknowledge differences and the diversity of reasons why people are taking part.

After each person has shared, as a facilitator you can also share why you chose to lead the session and what your motivations are for creating the space for the young people themselves.

Discussion 2: Hopes and fears

Invite each person to write down on one side of a small piece of paper:

What they hope to experience or gain from being part of the group.

And on the other side:

The strongest fear they have about being part of the group.

Invite them to fold the piece of paper and place it in a small box or container. After mixing the pieces of paper, bring the box/ container around the group and ask them to pick one out, without opening it. Take time to go round the group, asking them to read out the hope and fear that is written on the paper.

Discussion 3: Creating a group contract

Invite each person to find a new partner and discuss the following questions for 5-10 minutes:

What qualities and behaviours can you personally bring to this group to help create a space where people feel comfortable being themselves?

What do you need from the group to help you feel safe to share your views and experiences?

What would prevent you from feeling safe and able to express yourself in the group?

Invite each pair to feedback to the main group a list of qualities and behaviours that emerged from their discussions.

Record their responses on a piece of paper or in a digital document that can be saved and given to the group at the beginning of the next session to remind them of their group contract.

Let the group know that they can add to the group contract at any time if they feel there is something that is missing or they would like to change.

After establishing the group contract, discuss as a group:

How will the group respond if the group's rules and boundaries are crossed by somebody?

Discussion 4: Confidentiality

Invite the group to describe their understanding of confidentiality.

Ask the group for their views on situations where it may be necessary to break confidentiality and share the information with a parent or a member of staff within the setting.

Clearly outline the meaning of confidentiality and ensure that everybody understands and acknowledges when confidentiality rules may need to be broken to ensure every young person is protected from harm.